HENRY FORD: HUMANITARIAN AND BUSINESSMAN?

Other American industrialists and factory managers were stunned when automobile manufacturer Henry Ford announced in 1914 that he would pay his assembly line workers $5.00 a day and reduce the working day from nine to eight hours. The average daily wage in American industry at the time was $2.34. He became world famous almost overnight. Opponents derided Ford as a socialist, while supporters called him a great humanitarian. Actually, Ford had simply come to understand that mass production required a society composed of many consumers, not just a few wealthy people amid a multitude of poor. He was making cars for the middle class and knew that sales depended on the existence of a middle class able to afford them, preferably including his own workers. This notion went against the grain of most American businessmen, who believed that low wages, coupled with the highest possible prices, were necessary to make a profit.

EXERCISE 1: Find words or phrases in the passage which mean the same as:

	COLUMN A	COLUMN B
a)	(be) shocked	
b)	a production process in a factory where each worker does one task before the product is moved on to the next worker *(phrase)*	
c)	in a very short period of time	
d)	mock someone because you consider him foolish	
e)	a person who does things for the general good of people or society	
f)	only; merely	
g)	the system of making large numbers of the same item *(phrase)*	
h)	a person who buys a product	
i)	among	
j)	a very large number	
k)	idea	
l)	be in conflict with normal behaviour *(phrase)*	
m)	together with *(phrase)*	

EXERCISE 2: Choose the correct answer according to the passage.

1. We can infer from the passage that Henry Ford revolutionized American industry by.....

A) producing automobiles everyone could afford
B) preaching socialist values to his own employees
C) setting new standards in wages and working hours
D) making people work in factories from 8 to 9 hours each day
E) supporting consumers although he himself was a manufacturer

2. The principal motivation behind Ford's pay scheme was.....

A) to attract skillful workers from other companies
B) to make other wealthy business owners help the poor
C) to redistribute wealth by giving more money to the poor
D) to eliminate the need for charitable organizations
E) to create a larger market for mass-produced goods

3. The passage informs us that, before Henry Ford's innovations, American businessmen

A) depended heavily on the middle class both as employees and as customers
B) refused to pay workers more than $2.34 for each nine-hour shift of work
C) were well-known for their generosity and concern for poor people
D) believed in making profit margins high by keeping wages low
E) didn't devote much effort to the concept of producing high quality goods

EXERCISE 3: Complete the sentences by selecting words from Column B in EXERCISE 1.

1. Jeff is practising his guitar vigorously for hours every day, but he has no intention of becoming a professional musician; he.....loves to play it.
2. When Columbus suggested that it was possible to sail to India by going west, instead of east, many people.....him for his idea.
3. In the 1960s, many people decided to.....and live in a manner in conflict with the rest of society - they were known as hippies and were often harrassed by the police.
4. My friend Lucy has the strange.....that she is the least-liked person in her family. I don't know where she got this idea from, but she's convinced it's true.
5. When her telephone bill arrived, Helen was.....-she had expected it to be around £25, but it was, in fact, closer to £200.